

The Hand That Writes in Heaven

Key Verse: "Then was the part of the hand sent from him; and this writing was written." — Daniel 5:24

There is a book in heaven. It is not a figure of speech, nor a mere metaphor to comfort the anxious heart. It is a reality more solid than the ground beneath our feet. The Scriptures speak of it from beginning to end with sober consistency. Moses, in the wilderness, cried out to God on behalf of a rebellious people: "Yet now, if thou wilt forgive their sin—; and if not, blot me, I pray thee, out of thy book which thou hast written" (Exodus 32:32). David, in the anguish of his soul, prayed against the wicked: "Let them be blotted out of the book of the living, and not be written with the righteous" (Psalm 69:28). Malachi, the last voice of the old covenant, declared that "a book of remembrance was written before him for them that feared the LORD, and that thought upon his name" (Malachi 3:16). And in the fullness of the new covenant, the writer of Hebrews speaks of "the general assembly and church of the firstborn, which are written in heaven" (Hebrews 12:23). The beloved John, exiled on Patmos, saw the same book and warned that "whosoever was not found written in the book of life was cast into the lake of fire" (Revelation 20:15).

God keeps records. He is not a forgetful deity, nor an indifferent observer of the affairs of men. Every deed, every word, every secret thought is inscribed by the finger of God in the archives of eternity. The prophet Daniel understood this when he stood before Belshazzar and declared, "Thou art weighed in the balances, and art found wanting" (Daniel 5:27). The weighing had already occurred. The record had already been made. The only thing left was the reading of the sentence. This is the terror and the wonder of Daniel chapter five. Belshazzar, the king of Babylon, had gathered a thousand of his lords for a night of drunken revelry. In his arrogance, he called for the golden and silver vessels that his grandfather Nebuchadnezzar had taken from the temple in Jerusalem, and he drank wine from them while praising "the gods of gold, and of silver, of brass, of iron, of wood, and of stone" (Daniel 5:4). He took that which was holy and made it common. He mocked the God of Israel while the very breath of life was in his nostrils. "But the God in whose hand thy breath is, and whose are all thy ways, hast thou not glorified" (Daniel 5:23).

Then came the moment that silenced the music and froze the laughter. "In the same hour came forth fingers of a man's hand, and wrote over against the candlestick upon the plaister of the wall of the king's palace: and the king saw the part of the hand that wrote" (Daniel 5:5). The hand did not appear in the temple. It did not appear in the heavens above the city. It appeared in the banquet hall, in the midst of the revelry, directly opposite the lampstand, so that its writing could not be missed. God was not shouting from the mountaintop. He was writing on the wall of a man's own house, in the presence of his own guests, at the very hour of his greatest folly. "Then the king's countenance was changed, and his thoughts troubled him, so that the joints of his loins were loosed, and his knees smote one against another" (Daniel 5:6).

But here is the truth that should make every soul tremble and every knee bow: the hand that became visible that night was not writing something new. It was making what had already been written visible in heaven. The record of Belshazzar's life had been accumulating for years. Every act of idolatry, every abuse of power, every moment of pride had been inscribed in the book of God. The hand on the wall was not a sudden punishment from a distant God. It was a revelation of what had always been true. Heaven had been writing all along. The wall simply caught up with the ledger. Consider the patience of God that preceded this moment. For decades, the Lord had borne with Belshazzar. He had given him breath and life and riches and power. "The LORD is longsuffering, and of great mercy, forgiving iniquity and transgression" (Numbers 14:18). "The Lord is not slack concerning his promise, as some men count slackness; but is longsuffering to us-ward, not willing that any should perish, but that all should come to repentance" (2 Peter 3:9). Every sunrise was a call to repentance. Every meal was a mercy. Every breath was a gift. But Belshazzar consumed these gifts upon his lusts and gave no thought to the Giver. And so the hand appeared.

This is the case with every person who has ever lived. The hand does not need to appear for the writing to continue. Just because the fingers have not traced letters of fire upon your bedroom wall does not mean the record is blank. "For God shall bring every work into judgment, with every secret thing, whether it be good, or whether it be evil" (Ecclesiastes 12:14). Our Lord Himself declared, "But I say unto you, That every idle word that men shall speak, they shall give account thereof in the day of judgment" (Matthew 12:36). Every idle word. Every careless glance. Every hidden motive. Every neglected opportunity. Every moment of pride, every act of selfishness, every secret sin that we imagine no one sees—all of it is being written. The hand is moving. The ink is permanent. The book is growing.

Consider what is being written in heaven right now. Consider what is being recorded in the book concerning you. The world may not see it. Your family may not know it. Your church may not suspect it. But "the eyes of the LORD are in every place, beholding the evil and the good" (Proverbs 15:3). "Yea, the darkness hideth not from thee; but the night shineth as the day: the darkness and the light are both alike to thee" (Psalm 139:12). "Neither is there any creature that is not manifest in his sight: but all things are naked and opened unto the eyes of him with whom we have to do" (Hebrews 4:13). The hand is writing. The question is not whether it will appear. The question is what it is writing.

And yet, here is the mercy that shines through the darkness. The same Bible that speaks of the book of judgment also speaks of a book of life, and it tells us of a Savior who was blotted out in the place of His people. The Lord Jesus Christ, on the night He was betrayed, took the cup and said, "This cup is the new testament in my blood, which is shed for you" (Luke 22:20). He bore the curse of the record. "But he was wounded for our transgressions, he was bruised for our iniquities: the chastisement of our peace was upon him; and with his stripes we are healed" (Isaiah 53:5). The handwriting that was against us—the record of our debt—He took out of the way, nailing it to His cross. "Blotting out the handwriting of ordinances that was against us, which was contrary to us, and took it out of the way, nailing it to his cross" (Colossians 2:14). The hand that wrote judgment upon the wall of Belshazzar's palace was the same hand that was nailed to the cross for the sins of the world. The God who writes is the God who saves. The Judge is the Redeemer.

But let no one presume. The mercy of God is not a license to sin. Belshazzar saw the hand and still did not repent. He offered Daniel gifts and honors, but his heart was not broken. He was slain that very night. "In that night was Belshazzar the king of the Chaldeans slain" (Daniel 5:30). The writing on the wall was his final warning, and he despised it. So it is with every soul that hears the gospel and delays. The hand is writing. The record is growing. The book will be opened. "And I saw the dead, small and great, stand before God; and the books were opened: and another book was opened, which is the book of life: and the dead were judged out of those things which were written in the books, according to their works" (Revelation 20:12).

Let us always consider what is being written in heaven. Let us live with the fear of the Lord, which is the beginning of wisdom. "The fear of the LORD is the beginning of wisdom: and the knowledge of the holy is understanding" (Proverbs 9:10). Let us remember that our lives are not hidden from God, that our secrets are not secret to Him, and that the hand of

judgment is the hand of a Savior who offers forgiveness to all who repent. The writing continues. The book is open. The hand is moving.

A Second Reflection: The Hand That Wrote Was a Hand That Had Been Writing All Along

The most chilling detail in Daniel 5 is not the writing itself but the fact that it was a surprise. Belshazzar was not expecting it. He had lived his entire life in the presence of a God who was recording every moment, and he had no idea. This is the condition of every unregenerate soul. The carnal mind does not perceive the invisible hand. "But the natural man receiveth not the things of the Spirit of God: for they are foolishness unto him: neither can he know them, because they are spiritually discerned" (1 Corinthians 2:14). The wicked say, "How doth God know? and is there knowledge in the most High?" (Psalm 73:11). They live as practical atheists, conducting their affairs as though heaven were empty and the book were closed. But the hand had been writing from the moment of Belshazzar's birth. His first cry, his first step, his first act of will—all recorded. His elevation to the throne, his first decree, his first feast—all inscribed. The hand that appeared on the wall that night was not a visitor from a distant realm. It was the same hand that had been writing in the book of his life since the day he drew breath. The wall simply made visible what the book had always contained. This is the terror of the unconverted life. You are not living in a vacuum. You are living in the sight of an all-seeing God who has never once looked away. The hand is not still. The ink is not dry.

And here is the deeper horror: Belshazzar's own grandfather, Nebuchadnezzar, had been humbled by God and had written a public testimony of his repentance. "Now I Nebuchadnezzar praise and extol and honour the King of heaven, all whose works are truth, and his ways judgment: and those that walk in pride he is able to abase" (Daniel 4:37). That testimony was in the royal archives. Belshazzar had access to it. He knew what God had done to his grandfather. He knew the God of Israel was not a myth. And yet he drank from the sacred vessels anyway. His sin was not ignorance. It was defiance. "And thou his son, O Belshazzar, hast not humbled thine heart, though thou knewest all this" (Daniel 5:22). The writing on the wall was not the beginning of his judgment. It was the end of a long conversation he had refused to hear. God had been speaking for years. The hand had been writing for decades. The wall was the final syllable of a sentence that had been spoken since his birth.

A Third Reflection: The Writing on the Wall Was Read by a Man Who Could Not Read It

Consider this: Belshazzar saw the hand. He saw the letters. But he could not understand them. The text was in Aramaic, a language he knew well, and yet the words were veiled to him. His wise men could not read it either. "Then came in all the king's wise men: but they could not read the writing, nor make known to the king the interpretation thereof" (Daniel 5:8). The queen had to remind him of Daniel. And Daniel, a captive Jew, a man who had been carried from Jerusalem as a boy, was the only one in the entire kingdom who could interpret the writing. Why? Because the writing was not merely a message in a language. It was a verdict from a court. And only a man who walked with the Judge could read the verdict.

This reveals something profound about the judgment of God. The wicked are often blind to their own judgment. They see the evidence but cannot interpret it. They witness the hand but cannot read the writing. "The way of the wicked is as darkness: they know not at what they stumble" (Proverbs 4:19). Belshazzar saw the wall. He saw the letters. He saw the hand. But he did not see his own doom until a prophet told him. And even then, he did not repent. He simply offered Daniel rewards and went back to his feast. "Then commanded Belshazzar, and they clothed Daniel with scarlet, and put a chain of gold about his neck, and made a proclamation concerning him, that he should be the third ruler in the kingdom" (Daniel 5:29). The writing was clear. The interpretation was certain. But the king's heart was harder than the wall upon which the message was written.

This is the condition of every soul that hears the Word of God and rejects it. The truth is not hidden. The writing is on the wall. The book is open. The gospel is preached. But the natural man cannot receive it. He sees the letters but cannot read the message. He hears the words but cannot understand the verdict. Only the Spirit of God can open the eyes of the blind and give understanding to the foolish. "But God hath revealed them unto us by his Spirit: for the Spirit searcheth all things, yea, the deep things of God" (1 Corinthians 2:10). And here is the mercy: the same hand that wrote judgment on Belshazzar's wall wrote grace on the ground when a woman caught in adultery was brought before Jesus. "This they said, tempting him, that they might have to accuse him. But Jesus stooped down, and with his finger wrote on the ground, as though he heard them not" (John 8:6). The same finger that inscribed the doom of Babylon inscribed the forgiveness of a sinner. The hand that writes in heaven is the hand that

was nailed to the cross. The question is not whether the writing will appear. The question is whether you will read it while there is still time to repent.

"Seek ye the LORD while he may be found, call ye upon him while he is near: Let the wicked forsake his way, and the unrighteous man his thoughts: and let him return unto the LORD, and he will have mercy upon him; and to our God, for he will abundantly pardon" (Isaiah 55:6-7).